political prisoners, economic reforms, and national reconciliation. The protesters were determined to continue in spite of the possibility of harsh reprisals.

Late in the evening of September 25, authorities began to arrest some of the prominent public figures who had come out to support the protest movement. Opposition politician U Win Naing and comedian Zargana were both detained that evening. Other high-profile citizens went into hiding at this time. The military moved in large numbers, occupying parts of Rangoon. Riot police also were deployed in key strategic positions.

The eastern side of Shwedagon pagoda bore the brunt of a major onslaught from the riot police and military units. General Khin Ye oversaw the operation. Barbed wire barricades were placed in the entrance to the pagoda. Monks were detained and the crowds that gathered grew more anxious. Shortly after, teargas and violent action commenced. The riot police cracked down on the protesters in a brutal fashion. Monks and student were beaten relentlessly. The riot police beat and took into detention trapped monks, who fled back to the monastery. Evidence of the ordeal was quickly removed as the regime cleaned the areas of blood and debris. Key intersections were blocked, making any further organized resistance difficult. The area around Thakin Mya Park saw some of the heaviest casualties during the first day of the crackdown. Live ammunition was used against protesters who decided to sit in the streets chanting Buddhists prayers as part of the protest. Bodies would be quickly carted off, following a pattern that would be repeated frequently. The following day a curfew was implemented and the security forces raided monasteries and arrested Buddhist leaders. During the cover of night, multiple raids took place, which included the looting and destruction of numerous monasteries. Citizens were outraged, but could do little to stop the onslaught by the military and police. By the morning of September 27, massive arrests were recorded and multiple injuries and fatalities resulted. The response escalated quickly as the military, rather than police authorities, took control over quelling the protests. An essential part of the tatmadaw's plan was to lessen the influence of the monks in the protest movement. The initial step of closing monasteries and keeping the monks away from the mass movement was significant in stifling the momentum of the protest.